

The Journey to the Land of Youth

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



The Journey to the Land of Youth

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

A small friend of the village has gone missing. Yesterday they ran after a white deer, down to the Misty Loch and across the water, into the Land of Youth. That is the gentle Otherworld, once called Tir na nOg, where no one ever grows old. It is a lovely place. That is the danger. The longer your friend stays there, the more they forget the way home.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver calls you to her side. "You two have clever heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you cross the mist and bring our friend gently home, before they forget us altogether?"

She gives you three gifts: a sprig of oak for luck, a honey oatcake to share, and a ball of red wool. Then she smiles. "Here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Cleverness, of Courage, or of Kindness?

Stop 1: The Salmon's Riddle

You come down to the shore of the Misty Loch. The water is grey and still. How will you ever cross?

Then a great silver fish rises up in the ripples. It is the Salmon of Wisdom, old and bright and kind. "I know the way across," he says, "and I will tell you, if you can answer my riddle."

Could you listen closely and think it through together? A brave, thoughtful guess is allowed too. Try something and see.

When you answer, the salmon swishes his tail in the water. "Well thought," he says. He shows you where to wait for the boat.

Stop 2: The Selkie's Crossing

By the reeds waits Sorchá the Selkie, a gentle seal-person in a soft grey cloak. She has a little wooden boat. But she is shy, and she looks a little lonely, and she will not quite meet your eyes.

This is not a thing to win by force. How could you be kind to her? You could give her a warm word. You could share your honey oatcake. What do you try?

When you are kind, Sorchá smiles for the first time in a long while. "Climb in," she says softly. She rows you out into the mist, and on the far side waits the Land of Youth.

Stop 3: The Land of Youth

You step ashore into the Otherworld. The apple trees are all in blossom, the light is golden, and there is your friend, laughing in the flowers. But when you call their name, they only half remember you. "Stay," they say. "Stay here forever. It is always lovely here."

It would be easy to stay. That is the danger. But you remember home: the warm Roundhouse, the people who love you, the way the loch shines at dawn.

This is not a fight. How will you help your friend remember home? You could tell them about home until they smile. You could tie the red wool so you can all find the way back. What do you do?

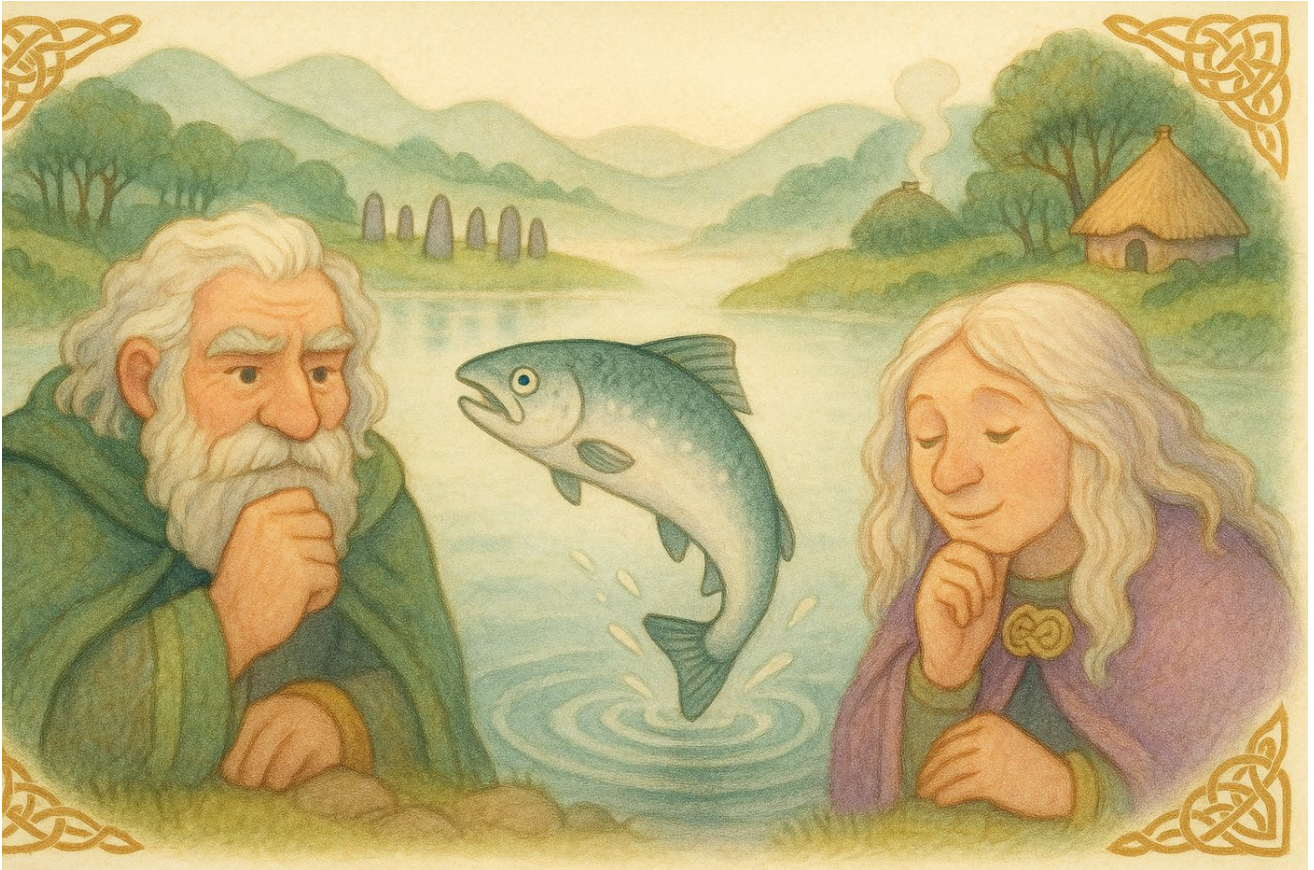
Gently, kindly, you help your friend remember. Their eyes clear. "Home," they say. "Yes. Let's go home together." You tie the red wool tight, and you all choose, together, to return.

Home Across the Mist

Sorcha is waiting in her boat, and she rows you all back across the water, following the red wool home. The mist parts. There is the green shore, bright in the morning sun, your friend safe and smiling beside you.

You came home together, and you have a selkie friend now too. High on the green hills, Danu the Kind smiles down at you. You did it. You were clever, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes.

The Story in Pictures



A bright old silver salmon rising from a still misty loch beside two older heroes thinking hard on the shore.



A gentle selkie in a grey sealskin cloak rowing two older heroes across a misty loch in a small boat, the heroes offering a smile and an oatcake.



A blossoming otherworld of ever-flowering apple trees and soft golden light, two older heroes kindly taking a small friend by the hand to lead them home.



Two older heroes and a small friend safely back on the home loch shore at sunrise, a gentle selkie waving from the water, a kind goddess smiling from the green hills.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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